

If Yan can cook...



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Editor

**I've found that
geekdom knows
no age or sex - I've
had interesting
conversations with
octogenarians who
share this magazine
with their teenage
grandchildren**

Back in 1998, when Digit wasn't yet called Digit, and right through 2001 when it was re-christened, I used to be a faithful reader. To be honest, before I started reading this magazine, computers scared me. I was terrified of corrupting the hard drive, or doing anything that would cause the PC to crash — which actually used to happen quite often on Windows 98.

I spent a couple of years playing the occasional game, but doing little else on the PC, because I didn't know where to start. It was my wife who first bought me this magazine, presumably because she was tired of starting up her PC for me, and showing me how to access the Yahoo! mail account she had created for me.

Just like in school, where certain subjects become our favourites, more because we like the teacher rather than the subject matter itself, Digit became my technology navigator, and technology my favourite subject.

I found mIRC on the Digit CD, and became an IRC junkie, learning a lot from the hackers and virus writers that populated some of the IRC chat rooms back then. Some of those people even sent me viruses over IRC that crashed Windows, but thanks to Digit, I just shrugged it off, formatted, re-installed, and was back on IRC in no time flat.

Digit also introduced me to open source, and I promptly lost the Windows partition, and all my wife's data, to a rather stubborn Mandrake boot loader. In hindsight, I suppose I was the stubborn one, and perhaps should have left the boot loader's default settings alone; but where's the fun in that?

Then, a little over 7 years ago, I was tempted by an advertisement in Digit, which called for CVs of interested candidates. The requirements? A passion for technology, nothing more; and I've been here ever since.

The reason I bring all this up is because over the years, I've met a lot of people who still seem to be in awe of technology and the advancements we've seen. I've also seen people who don't want to try new things, like Linux, because they're too scared to experiment, or too comfortable to change — until they start reading Digit, that is.

I received a call recently, from a subscriber who had retired from the armed forces, and he was looking to get some instructions on how to use the Ubuntu ISO file on the DVD. Obviously, I decided to be careful, and reminded him that there was a chance that if he didn't choose the right options, he might lose his Windows partition. The answer I got was, "Oh I know that, thanks to Digit I backup regularly, so I'm not worried about losing anything."

He also told me later that after reading Digit, he now discourages piracy amongst his friends and colleagues by suggesting open source and free alternatives to them. He had just one request — to dedicate the back page of the magazine to beginners, who might find some of our more techy articles intimidating, and help them ease into the Digit world. Thus, Digit 101 was born.

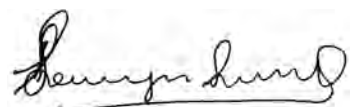
Over the years, after speaking to thousands of Digit readers, over mail, phone and the Digit forum (thinkdigit.com/forum), I've found that geekdom knows no age or sex — I've had interesting conversations with octogenarians who share this magazine with their teenage grandchildren.

Now to explain the headline on this page...

I grew up watching Martin Yan, on his famous cooking show, where the line, "If Yan can cook, so can you," was made famous. That simple one liner sticks with you, because even if you replace the words "Yan" and "cook" with an appropriate proper noun and verb, it still makes uncanny sense.

So, the next time you see a family member, friend, neighbour or acquaintance struggling to understand technology, share your copy of Digit with them — and perhaps, ask them to read the back page first. Also remind them to persevere; because even if they're overwhelmed by technology at first, just as you and I once were, it does get easier, and fairly quickly, so long as you have your technology navigator for company.

Besides, remember, "If Yan can cook...". 


editor@thinkdigit.com